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HR Due Diligence Readiness

What a buyer is likely to ask HR for, ranked, and where Copilot can help

Prepared for Erin Hughes, Ph.D., The Haverford Trust Company, by Caroline Hinton, Growth Partner Pros. November 2026.

Why this list

Erin, here's the stack-ranked list I promised. If a transaction moves forward, the buyer's team will send HR a long request list, usually with short deadlines and in a format of their choosing. This puts that list in order, so you can see what's almost certain to come and what can wait.

I built it for a wealth management and trust firm of about 150 people with a small HR team, using published buyer request lists, banking and securities rules and recent deal commentary. The ranking itself is my judgment.

> This is a readiness guide, not legal advice. Your deal counsel and the buyer's actual request list come first. Anything that touches agreements, classification, benefits or pay should go past counsel before you change it.

Where I'd start

You don't need to do all of this now. These three steps cover the requests most likely to come first, and each one makes the rest easier:

1. **One restricted place for diligence files**
   A SharePoint library with access limited to named people. Move files into it rather than copying them, so there's one version of everything.
2. **The employee census**
   One reconciled spreadsheet of everyone. Almost every other request leans on it.
3. **Every signed agreement in one folder**
   Offer letters, employment agreements and restrictive covenants. For an advisory firm, this is often the request most likely to affect price.

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THE RANKED LIST

What a buyer is likely to ask for

Likelihood. Near certain: on almost every buyer's first request list. Likely: most buyers of a wealth and trust firm will ask, usually in the first or second round. Possible: depends on the buyer and the deal structure.

Effort, assuming the documents exist and someone has to find, check and organize them. Light: a few hours to a day. Medium: two to five working days. Heavy: one to three weeks of on-and-off work. If something has to be created from scratch, plan for about double.

#	Request	Likelihood	Effort
1	**Employee census**	Near certain	Medium
2	**Client relationships and advisor dependency map**	Near certain	Heavy
3	**Employment agreements and restrictive covenants**	Near certain	Heavy
4	**Compensation, bonus and incentive plans**	Near certain	Medium
5	**Change-in-control, severance and retention arrangements**	Near certain	Light to Medium
6	**Licensing, registrations and designations roster**	Near certain	Heavy
7	**Benefit plans: retirement and health**	Near certain	Medium
8	**Employment claims and complaint history**	Near certain	Light to Medium
9	**Handbook and core policies**	Near certain	Light if current
10	**Org chart and key roles**	Near certain	Light
11	**Succession plans**	Likely	Light to Heavy
12	**Turnover and retention data**	Likely	Light to Medium
13	**Wage and hour classification**	Likely	Medium
14	**Background checks and Section 19 compliance**	Likely	Medium
15	**Director and officer information for regulators**	Likely	Light for HR
16	**Advisory contracts and client consent**	Likely	Light for HR
17	**Job descriptions, titles and pay structure**	Likely	Medium
18	**Required training and acknowledgment records**	Likely	Medium
19	**HR systems, employee data and privacy**	Likely	Medium
20	**AI governance**	Likely	Light to Medium
21	**Culture and engagement surveys**	Likely	Light
22	**EEO-1 reports and pay equity**	Likely	Light to Medium
23	**I-9 forms**	Likely	Medium
24	**Performance management records**	Possible	Medium
25	**Leaves, PTO balances and open employee matters**	Possible	Light
26	**Contractors, consultants and temps**	Possible	Light

A bank or trust company buyer is likely to add regulatory questions to these, and the deal structure changes how much history a buyer digs into. Counsel will know which applies.

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WHERE AI HELPS

Five places Copilot can carry real weight

Copilot is good with words: finding, summarizing and drafting. Excel, SharePoint and people handle the math, the permissions and the final call.

3 **Employment agreements and restrictive covenants**
Once the agreements sit in one folder, Copilot can help pull the same key terms out of each one into a single grid. A person checks every row against the signed copy, and counsel decides what's enforceable.

1 **Employee census**
Copilot in Excel can help spot blank fields, duplicates and inconsistent titles, and draft a key that explains each column. Excel's own formulas do the matching and totals.

19 **HR systems, employee data and privacy**
A structured SharePoint library with permissions set by folder protects you twice: it answers the buyer's questions, and it keeps Copilot to what each person is already allowed to see.

6 **Licensing and designations roster**
A SharePoint list with a reminder ahead of each renewal. Copilot drafts the requests to employees and summarizes who's missing what; checking public records stays with a person.

20 **AI governance**
An up-to-date AI policy, a simple inventory of the tools people actually use, and settings that back the policy up. A short staff survey in Microsoft Forms, summarized by Copilot, finds what's been missed.

Two ways I could help

Refresh the AI policy
Bring the October 2025 policy up to date with how Copilot works now, before staff are asked to sign it again. It's small, and it doubles as a diligence answer.

Build a diligence-ready HR foundation
Set up the restricted SharePoint library, reconcile the census and build the agreements grid, with Copilot doing the heavy lifting. These are the first three steps above.

Next step

Once you've had a chance to look this over, let's find 30 minutes to talk through what matters most to you and where I can help. I also have a fuller write-up on each request, including what buyers usually look for and what tends to raise questions, and I'm happy to walk you through it.

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